THE HOSTEL DOOR

DEVDEEP SAHA

Hello readers!

Guess who just traded the dull world of textbooks for the exciting chaos of words? Yup, it's me – your friendly neighbourhood college student turned wannabe writer. I've officially upgraded from doodling in class to typing out my thoughts.

Now, I know what you're thinking, "Shouldn't you be studying for that upcoming exam?" Well, I'm here to tell you, my friend, writing stories is practically the same as studying, right? Right. Let's just pretend it is.

Now, I'm no Ruskin Bond. But hey, who says writing can't be a 'bhelpuri' of thoughts? So, join me on this hilarious journey as I navigate through my writing journey and trying to sound mysterious when all I want is a good 'samosa.'

Buckle up, it's gonna be a rollercoaster of sentences, probably more confusing than figuring out why Maggi tastes better at 2 AM. But hey, it's all in good fun.

Let me know how you thought about this story till I write the next part. Also, if you have any exciting ideas which you are too lazy to write (P.s not me) do let me know!

Keep your coffee ready because you are going to have sleepless nights

Happy reading!

Yours favourite (gonna be if not now),

Devdeep

Index

Part 1

- Day 1
- Day 2
- Day 3 and 4
- Day 5
- Strange events
- The mirrored him
- Reverse countdown

Part 2

i. A hidden place
ii. The confession
iii. The morning
iv. Mysterious Manuscripts
v. The storm
vi. The discovery

Day 1

A boy, nineteen-year-old, listening to Bengali pop songs as he completes his daily morning jog. Rono is living in Kolkata for the past one year for his B. Tech degree. He is an excellent athlete and lived in hostel with other boys. His days go lazily with a little adda in the nearby tea stall.

Rono has only one hobby, and that is his collection of watches. He loves to wear all kind of watches for different occasions but he has a favourite smartwatch which he wears all day. Rono also daydreamed of being a detective after reading Byomkesh Bakshi, Feluda, Sherlock Holmes. In his family he only has one elder sister, he doesn't remember his mom and dad. He heard stories about them from his sister. Rono heard that his dad got killed in an accident when he was only 3 years old.

As Rono was finishing his usual day, the sound of his steps on the path and the sweet tunes in his ears made him look forward to the coziness of his hostel room. The night was quiet, only his steps echoed as he neared his room. His roommate went home a few days back.

As he opened the door, the soft light of his desk lamp uncovered a typical student's life – books scattered on bed, sports clothes on a chair, and a faint smell of quick noodles lingering.

The hostel food made him miss his home. His sister would lovingly cook him his favourite dishes. Rono went to have his dinner at 9 pm then he came back in his room and flipped open his laptop. This was his study hour and he didn't want to get disturbed.

Suddenly, knocks broke the silence disrupting the peace of his room. Rono looked at the time. It was 11:30 pm. Who could be knocking so late?

As the knocks stopped, a strange quiet filled the room. Rono hesitated, approaching the door. His hand shook as he slowly turned the doorknob and opened the door.

To his surprise, no one was there – only the dimly lit corridor and the distant hum of the hostel. The mystery lingered, leaving Rono questioning if it was a prank, a figment of his imagination, or something more elusive.

Day 2

As the new day dawned, Rono shrugged off the strange incident from the night before, attributing it to a mischievous prankster. Day two unfolded much like the previous one – the rhythms of his morning run, the uplifting melodies accompanying his steps, and the familiar routine of his day college classes. Yet, beneath the surface of his seemingly normal day, a sense of unease lingered.

Despite the vibrant activities that filled his day, Rono couldn't shake off the nagging curiosity about the mysterious knocks. The memory lingered in the back of his mind, like a puzzle piece waiting to be fitted into place. As the day unfolded, he found himself glancing at his door more than once, half-expecting an explanation for the perplexing events.

When the clock struck 11:30 pm once again, the same peculiar sensation settled in. This time, however, a tinge of irritation accompanied it. As the knocks echoed through his room, Rono's patience wore thin. His initial dismissal of the incident transformed into a frustration. With a furrowed brow, he swung the door open, half-expecting to catch the elusive prankster red-handed.

Swinging open the door, expecting to catch the phantom prankster, Rono was met with emptiness. The corridor stood silent. Rono’s face was mixed with anger and confusion. Rono roamed the corridor if he could find anyone hiding in the corner but all the doors were closed. He went to his best friend’s room which was 2 rooms after his.

Arjun, busy on his laptop, looked up.

Arjun: "Hey, buddy! What's with the puzzled look?"

Rono: "You won't believe what just happened. I was in my room, doing my thing, and then bam! More knocks on my door."

Arjun: *Raises an eyebrow* "Again? Man, you should put up a sign saying 'No Knocking Zone.' What's going on?"

‘That's the weird part. I opened the door, and no one was there. It's like the hostel ghost is playing pranks.’

Arjun laughs "You're turning our hostel into a mystery movie, dude. Maybe it's a sign to add some excitement to your life."

Rono: "Excitement? I just want a good night's sleep without becoming the hero of a ghost story."

Arjun: "If the knocks keep happening, maybe we should check it out together. Ghostbusters, college edition?"

Rono: "More like 'Skipping Class to Investigate Midnight Knocks,' but sure, count me in. As long as it doesn't mess up my morning jog."

Arjun: *Laughs* "Deal, my ghost-hunting partner. Now, back to the real mystery – figuring out these assignment instructions."

And with that, Rono and Arjun got back to tackling college assignments, putting the ghostly knocks on hold, at least until the next mysterious interruption.

Day 3 and 4

As the third day settled into Rono's usual routine, that late-night mystery of knocks just stuck around like a puzzle he couldn't solve. Every day, the question mark in his mind got bigger, making his college days a bit more complicated than usual. It was like having a riddle hanging over his head, you know? Just one of those things that makes life a bit more interesting and confusing at the same time. On the third day the knocks repeated and no one seen again.

On the fourth day, the unease transformed into irritation. Rono, now visibly disturbed, decided to unravel the mystery that clung to his door at 11:30 pm.

Rono early in the morning went to Arjun’s room. ‘’Those knocks, they're back!"

Arjun: "Seriously? The ghost is on a roll, huh? What did you do this time?"

Rono: "I didn't do anything! I just opened the door, and it was like playing hide-and-seek with thin air. But this time, I'm not taking it lightly. I'm asking around if someone's messing with me."

The usual suspects, his fellow hostelers, became subjects of inquiry. "Anyone playing a prank?" he questioned, his tone carrying a hint of frustration. The dimly lit corridor stood silent, and the faces of his mates remained poker-faced.

"No mischief from our end," one of them finally admitted, but the mystery lingered. Rono, abandoning his morning jog for the first time, decided to find the prankster head-on.

The air hung heavy with unanswered questions, and Rono, despite his inquiry, found himself staring into the shadows of a mystery that refused to reveal its secrets. The fourth day passed, leaving behind an unresolved riddle, and Rono, weary but determined, prepared for another night that held the promise of answers or, perhaps, deeper mysteries.

Day 5

On the fifth day, as the clock ticked towards the strange hour, the familiar knocks echoed through Rono's room once again. Yet, a sudden shift occurred within him – irritation transformed into intrigue, and Rono became more curious.

In a moment of clarity, Rono's mind ignited like a bulb in a dark room. The knocks, like mysterious whispers, held a pattern. His gaze shifted to a piece of paper and a pen lying on his desk, and with a swift determination, he embarked on decoding the mysterious rhythm.

As the pen danced across the paper, the dots and dashes of Morse code revealed…

●●●● Pause….

● Pause…

●▬●● Pause...

●▬▬● Stop

"H-E-L-P," spelled the coded message.

A quiet gasp escaped Rono's lips, replaced by a silence. The mystery that had haunted his nights now stood before him, pleading for attention. The once-irritated young man found himself at the crossroads of a mysterious tale, a protagonist in a story that begged to be unfolded.

The usual irritation turned into a determination, and Rono, now powered by a fresh insight, geared up to go further into the shadows echoing the word "HELP." Little did he know that decoding this mysterious plea would involve more unexpected turns than trying to navigate a local market without Google Maps.

Rono opened the door and then again took a walk from the hostel corridor. A cold lazy breeze was blowing, he gazed at the moon thinking many different things. After all this Rono went back to his room and went to sleep, leaving the puzzling questions behind

The mysteries of the night were left to be figured out when he woke up.

Strange Events

As Rono woke up, things felt really weird. When he checked his mobile, the date showed the same day as yesterday. Even the clock in his room was going backward, ticking in a strange way. It made him feel a bit scared.

To make things stranger, Rono could predict what his friend would say, as if he had already lived through the day. Trying to understand, he opened his room door, and suddenly, everything changed. The air felt different, and he entered a place where time seemed to go in reverse.

In this odd world, the sun moved backward, trees got their leaves back, and birds flew in a funny way. Rono realized he had somehow stepped into a different universe where time worked in a way he couldn't understand. Each step he took led him into a past that was also a future, creating a confusing puzzle he had to solve.

As he explored this world where effects happened before causes, Rono felt like he was in a maze of time. The whispers of what had already happened and the echoes of what was yet to come mixed up in a strange harmony. In this place where yesterday and tomorrow got all mixed, Rono had to untangle the secrets of a reality that didn't follow the rules he knew.

The mirrored him

Rono pieced together the puzzle – the door wasn't just an ordinary door; it was a link to another place. The night he opened it and came back, he found himself in a different room, not his own. Trying to figure out how to return to his original world, he had an idea. He thought of asking for help from himself in another universe.

He thought he should try knocking the door so he grabbed a pen and paper to plan it out. Finally, he decided to use Morse code to send the message. After he stopped knocking, he suddenly looked at his smartwatch and he saw the time 11:30 am.

He thought, "If time is going backward here, it was me asking for help when I knocked! But why am I here, and what's the connection between these worlds? I hope my other self will find me and rescue me"

Rono stood at the door thinking “What a mess I am into? Why me?” The door, once a simple entrance and exit now holds a supernatural power. It was a peculiar movement between past and future, where Rono was both the seeker and the provider of help.

The journey, which started with an innocent jog and a mysterious knock, now unfolded into a cosmic mystery. Rono, armed with newfound understanding, looked at the door not just as a way to return home but as a portal that connected the threads of his own existence.

It's like he's a traveller looking for answers, but without realizing it, he's also giving some answers along the way. It's all a bit unexpected and puzzling, you know?

As Rono stood at the door, the meeting of mirrored selves was running through his mind.

Feeling a bit unsettled, Rono headed to the hostel canteen for a meal. Strangely, when he chatted with his friends, they seemed a bit off, like people he knew but not quite. It gave him an eerie feeling. A bit scared, he decided to call it a night without dwelling on it too much.

As he lay in bed, a weird sense of uncertainty lingered. Little did Rono know, the real mystery was just beginning.

Reverse Countdown

The next morning, Rono decided to skip college. Feeling a bit off, he took a stroll outside, hoping the fresh air would clear his mind. Upon returning to his room, he noticed something unusual – a magnifying glass that wasn't there in the other universe.

Curiosity getting the better of him, Rono picked it up and peered through. To his surprise, things looked a bit different, and when he focused on the clock, he was downright shocked. The hands were moving in the clockwise direction, just like in his original universe.

"Murmuring to himself, Rono muttered, "This can't be right. Am I still in the same place? What's with this weird magnifying glass?"

As he continued examining the room through the magnifying glass, he couldn't believe his eyes. "Wait, is that... my actual room?" he exclaimed, realizing that the magnifying glass somehow revealed a glimpse of his world. The mystery was deepening, and Rono couldn't help but feel a mix of confusion and excitement. It was like the magnifying glass was connecting both worlds. What other secrets did this peculiar magnifying glass hold?

A hidden place

In the midst of his thoughts, Rono's smartwatch buzzed, indicating a new location. Surprised, he glanced at the screen, which displayed a set of coordinates. The numbers seemed to point to a place he had never visited before.

"Hmm, a location? This just keeps getting weirder," Rono mumbled to himself, a mix of curiosity and colouring his thoughts. "Is this connected to the magnifying glass, or is it a whole new twist to the story?"

Driven by a newfound sense of adventure, Rono decided to follow the coordinates. He slipped the magical magnifying glass into his pocket, his mind buzzing with possibilities. As he stepped out, the air felt charged with anticipation, and the surroundings took on an unfamiliar aura.

Navigating through the twists and turns of the coordinates, Rono found himself standing in front of an old library – a place he had never noticed in his college town. The doors creaked as he pushed them open, revealing a dimly lit interior with towering bookshelves that seemed to reach the sky.

"Okay, this is getting seriously mysterious. A hidden library?" Rono thought, his eyes scanning the titles of ancient-looking books. "What secrets does this place hold? And how does it connect to the magnifying glass and those strange echoes of 'HELP'?"

As Rono continued his exploration in the hidden library, his eyes widened as he stumbled upon a section that seemed to hold a personal

connection. Among the titles, he saw a book with his father's name on it – a revelation that sent shivers down his spine.

"Wait, my father's name? What could he possibly have to do with all this?" Rono wondered aloud, his voice echoing softly in the hushed atmosphere of the library. He carefully pulled the book from the shelf, its cover bearing his father's name in elegant script.

Opening the book, Rono found a dedication inscribed on the first page. "To my son, Rono, may this knowledge guide you through the mysteries of life." The words, written in his father's handwriting, struck a chord deep within him.

In a mix of astonishment and disbelief, Rono whispered, "Dad? Are you somehow a part of this hidden world? What secrets were you exploring, and why did you leave these breadcrumbs for me to find?"

As he turned the pages, Rono noticed a series of diagrams that resembled the symbols seen through the magnifying glass. "This is getting more bizarre by the minute. Dad, what were you involved in, and how does it connect to my strange journey?" he mused, his mind swirling with a multitude of emotions.

The confession

As Rono went back to his hostel with those puzzling diagrams still on his mind, he found comfort in the familiar setting of his room.

Rono hesitated for a moment, wondering how to share this unusual story with Arjun. Inhaling deeply, he decided to lay it all out.

Rono: "Arjun, I've got something to tell you, and I need you to trust me, alright?"

Arjun, sensing the gravity in Rono's words, nodded with a furrowed brow.

Arjun: "Okay, spill it, Rono. What's going on?"

Rono: "I know this might sound a bit crazy, but hear me out. I'm not exactly from this time. I've been... traveling to a different time, where things unfold in a completely different way."

Arjun's eyes widened, a mix of disbelief and curiosity evident on his face.

Arjun: "Different time? Like time travel? You mean those sci-fi movies?"

Rono: *nodding* "Exactly. It all started with those weird knocks, and suddenly I found myself in a reality where events played out in ways I couldn't predict."

Arjun: *rubbing his temples* "This is insane, Rono. Are you sure you haven't been binge-watching too many bizarre shows?"

Rono: "I wish it were that simple, Arjun. But I need your help. I need someone to believe me, to figure out what's happening. I can't navigate this alone."

Arjun: "Wait, hold on. You're telling me that you're not the real Rono? And there's another you, the actual Rono, out there somewhere in a different time or reality?"

Rono: "I know, Arjun, it's a lot to take in. But trust me, I need your help to figure this out. The real me, the one you know, might be stuck somewhere, and I want to find him."

Arjun, still processing the revelation, stammered in astonishment.

Arjun: "But, how... I mean, which one is the real you?"

Rono: "That's what we need to find out. I believe there's a connection between those knocks, the strange time shifts, and these symbols in my dad's journal."

Arjun, though bewildered, nodded slowly, realizing the gravity of the situation.

Arjun: "Okay, Rono, let's get this straight. We're looking for the real you, the one I've known all along. And we're diving into some sci-fi mystery to do it?"

Rono: smirking "Exactly, Arjun. I know it sounds like a Bollywood plot, but I need my partner in time on this one. Are you in?"

Arjun, still grappling with the surreal reality of the situation, managed a hesitant but determined nod.

Arjun: "Alright, Rono, let's find the real you. And if things get too weird, I'm blaming you for this."

Rono, with a sense of urgency, quickly filled Arjun in on the latest developments.

Rono: "Arjun, I found a magnifying glass in my room. When I looked through it, things appeared differently. The clock was going in the right direction, like in our world. And there were coordinates."

Arjun: "Coordinates? What do they lead to?"

Rono: "I'm not sure, but my smartwatch showed a location. It led me to an old library with my dad's name on it. We need to go there and see if there's any connection to the symbols or my time travels."

Rono showed the Magnifying glass to Arjun. He was shocked to see things through this.

The night closed with a lingering sense of wonder, the moonlit hostel corridors holding secrets yet to be revealed.

The morning

The next morning Rono woke up with the sound of a cow mooing

(roosters don’t call in the morning here).

Rono looked at his watch, it didn’t have much battery left but it was enough to tell the time, it was 10 am in his universe.

Rono was really hungry and was thinking when was he going to have breakfast (it’s called dinner here).

Suddenly he got startled by a series of knocks! He felt that he heard those knocks before somewhere. He expected Arjun at this hour but when he opened the door he was startled!!!

Rono couldn’t believe his eyes,

Rono was face to face with another version of himself, from a parallel universe. Rono was paralysed for a moment before he could speak... He had never felt like this before

Other Rono: "Surprised to see me, aren't you?"

Original Rono, stammering: "Who... are you?"
(He almost forgot he was the one who called for help)

Other Rono, with a mysterious smile: "I'm you, or at least, a version of you from a different world. You can call me your doppelganger."

Original Rono, trying to comprehend: "Doppel... what?”

Other Rono, calmly: " We've got a lot to talk about. It's not every day you meet yourself from another universe."

At this moment Arjun enters the room and is bewildered.

Arjun, scratching his head: "Okay, what in the multiverse is happening here? Why are there two identical yous in the room? Are you the actual Rono my best friend!! How will I identify you two? You look more similar than identical twins!"

Arjun asks as many questions he could in a single breath.

Onor, with a sly smile: " Since we're from a world where things go a bit differently, I have come up with a solution."

Rono, looking perplexed: "A solution? "

Onor, pointing to himself: "Well, I was stuck in your world for a few days. You guys read left to right, right? In our world, we read things right to left. So, to make it simpler, you can call me Onor. It's just Rono spelled backward."

Arjun, raising an eyebrow: "Onor? Seriously? This is like some weird parallel universe version of a sitcom."

Onor, chuckling: "Believe me, Arjun, if this were a sitcom, I'd be asking for better writers. But alas, we're stuck in this mystery together."

Rono, leaning in to Onor, whispered with caution: "Listen, Onor, we can't have both of us roaming around at the same time in the hostel. It'll raise too many eyebrows. Only one of us should be out at any given time, got it?"

Onor, nodding in agreement: "Got it. So, what's the plan then?"

Rono, with a thoughtful look: "We'll take turns. I'll stay here while you explore, and vice versa. We can't risk anyone noticing there are two of us running around. Just play it cool and act like me. It's a strange situation, but we've got to keep it under wraps."

Onor, smirking: "Act like you, huh? This should be interesting. But yeah, I'm on board. Let's keep our little secret between us."

With this Onor and Arjun went to have dinner (breakfast for Rono) and bring food for Rono who was staying inside the room.

Silently, Rono and Onor slipped out of the room one by one, making their way towards the old library with a shared sense of purpose.

On the way Onor taught many rules of their universe

Onor, in hushed tones: "So, in my world, everything works a bit differently. Time doesn't follow the same rules, and events often unfold in unexpected ways. "

Onor, with a mysterious smile: "Well, for starters, the laws of physics are a bit more flexible. Imagine a reality where gravity might change direction at will. It's a world of constant surprises and perpetual unpredictability."

Rono didn’t know the meaning of perpetual unpredictability nor did he wanted to know. All he wanted to was to go back to his ordinary hostel life. But at least now he knew someone from this universe.

Rono, tried to understand it for a bit, "How do you manage it here!"

Onor, chuckling: "You get used to it. Adaptation is the key. It's a universe where the unexpected becomes the natural, we are seeing things like this from birth so we don't feel out of place. But enough about my world – let's focus on untangling this mystery here and now."

Mysterious Manuscripts

Rono, Onor and Arjun was standing near that haunting library. A chilly wind blew and the clouds roared as they would jump over them and won't let them enter the library.

Rono, looking at the sky, said, "Guys, I feel like the weather's going to get bad."

Arjun, joked, "Let's brave the storm, metaphorical or not."

Together they entered the old cranky library, things didn't seem to change from the previous day. Rono guided them to the bookshelf. Rono's eyes fell upon a row of old, dusty books. With a mix of excitement and uncertainty, he carefully pulled out a weathered tome and, pointing at the author's name, exclaimed, "Look, guys! My dad's name is right here – Anirban Chatterjee."

Arjun squinted at the faded letters, a flicker of recognition crossing his face. "Wait, isn't that your dad's name, Rono?"

Onor nodded, a sense of urgency in his voice, "Yes, it is. This is more than a coincidence."

Suddenly, Onor's eyes widened as a realization struck him. "Hold on, didn't they write from right to left in this universe? How is this book from Rono's universe even here?"

The trio exchanged puzzled glances; the mystery deepened.

Arjun suggested, "Let's take it to our hostel. We can read it there and figure out what's going on."

The storm

As they were about to leave, a massive storm erupted outside the library. The wind howled, and rain lashed against the windows fiercely. Onor, looking concerned, suggested they should stay inside until the storm calms down a bit.

Onor, shouting over the roaring storm, said, "Guys, it's crazy out there! We better wait until this storm settles. No point in getting drenched and blown away!"

Rono and Arjun nodded in agreement, realizing that waiting inside the shelter of the library was a much safer option. The trio settled back into their exploration of the mysterious books, the storm outside adding an extra layer of suspense to their already confusing adventure.

Rono, Onor, and Arjun formed a circle on the library floor. Onor, with a grin, commented, "I always wanted an adventure like this."

Arjun chuckled, "Well, you got more than you bargained for, Onor."

As they sat together, the conversation turned to sharing stories from their lives. Onor began, "You know, I've always been into music and art. I play a couple of instruments and love creating things."

Rono, looking intrigued, replied, "That's cool! I never really got into art. My thing is jogging and staying healthy."

Arjun, adding a touch of humour, said, "And I'm here, stuck between a fitness freak and an artist. What a combo!"

The trio laughed, realizing that despite their differences, this unexpected adventure had brought them together in a unique way. The storm outside seemed to echo their bond, turning an ordinary library into a haven of shared stories and newfound friendships.

The discovery

Amidst their conversation, Arjun's sharp ears picked up a peculiar sound, akin to water drops hitting a pool. They searched the entire library, but no signs of leakage were found. Rono, puzzled, remarked, "I see no leaks. Where is this sound echoing from?"

Following the faint noise, they reached a corner where a massive bookshelf, untouched for decades, stood. Curiosity took over, and all of them began rummaging through the books. Suddenly, Onor pulled a book, and it got stuck halfway. A switch clicked somewhere. They couldn’t believe what they saw.

They saw that the bookshelf was splitting in half like a door, revealing a concealed staircase. Onor, with a mixture of awe and excitement, said, "HIDDEN STAIRS!”

Arjun, equally amazed, added, "Looks like we've found our next adventure – underground, no less!" Rono, sensing the unfolding mystery, nodded, and the trio descended the hidden stairs.

In the dimly lit underground space, darkness surrounded them, and none of them had a source of light, Rono’s watch was already dead or else he would have used the flashlight. Disappointed but determined, Rono sighed, "We should've brought a torch."

Onor, ever optimistic, replied, "No worries! Now we know what to do next. Let's push that book back, and tomorrow, armed with torches, we'll explore further."

As the storm outside slowly vanished, the trio, with a mix of excitement and anticipation, headed back to the hostel.

Mirrored Magnifier

As they approached the hostel, the sky became dark. Arjun checked the surroundings while entering the hostel, then signals Rono and Onor to come one by one to Onor's room.

Rono now took out the book (which had his dad’s name written) and kept on the table. The table lamp was dimmer than usual, and it made the spooky atmosphere more eerie. Rono took out the special magnifying glass from his pocket. Upon opening the book Onor says,” I have seen these symbols somewhere but I don’t remember where.”

Rono sees through the magnifying glass. Some of the symbol glows but they don’t understand what was happening. Arjun touches one glowing symbol and suddenly a huge storm starts inside their room. Books and papers flew around like birds, swirling and dancing in the air. Shelves rattled like it was scared of the unknown. Curtains flapped wildly. It was like nature itself had come inside to play, showing off its power in every corner of the room.

And then suddenly the room became quiet and Rono and the boys vanished in thin air.

No one felt the absence of two boys from their hostel. (No one knew about Rono)